

Regional Healthcare Trust — Annual Workforce Planning Report 2024

1. Executive Summary

This workforce planning report covers staffing levels, recruitment activity, and human resource allocation across all departments of the Northern Regional Healthcare Trust for the financial year 2023-2024. The Trust employs a total of 4,312 full-time equivalent staff across 8 hospital sites and 34 community health centres serving a population of approximately 1.2 million people.

2. Staffing Overview

Clinical staffing levels remain 6.4% below the target establishment, consistent with national trends in NHS workforce shortages. Nursing vacancy rates stand at 11.2%, down from 14.7% in the previous year following a targeted international recruitment campaign. Medical staffing is at 94% of establishment with consultant vacancies concentrated in radiology, emergency medicine, and anaesthetics departments.

3. Recruitment & Retention

A total of 623 new appointments were made during the reporting period, of which 41% were international recruits primarily from India, the Philippines, and Nigeria. Staff turnover rate decreased to 13.1% from 16.8% the prior year, attributed to the introduction of flexible working arrangements and an enhanced wellbeing programme targeting mental health support and career development opportunities.

4. Training & Development

Mandatory training compliance improved to 89% across all staff groups, exceeding the 85% target for the first time in four years. Investment in clinical leadership development programmes increased by 22% to 1.4 million pounds. A new digital skills training initiative was launched in partnership with Health Education England with 1,847 staff completing foundational digital literacy modules by year end.

5. Workforce Planning Priorities 2025

Key priorities for the coming year include further reduction of nursing vacancy rates to below 8%, implementation of a new electronic rostering system across all sites, development of an allied health professional career framework, and expansion of the apprenticeship programme targeting 150 new

starts. Budget allocation for workforce development has been confirmed at 6.8 million pounds.